

Хорхе Месси был отцом, агентом и доверенным лицом Лионеля. Он разглядел талант сына раньше всех остальных



Лионель Месси и его отец Хорхе обнимаются после победы Аргентины в финале чемпионата мира по футболу 2022 года Robert Michael/Picture Alliance via Getty Images



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Мы видели фотографии разочарованного Лионеля Месси, стоящего в одиночестве на футбольном поле. Казалось, что его худшие поражения поглотили его в этом одиночестве. Что можно сказать человеку, который с точки зрения соперничества олицетворяет собой чрезмерный успех?

68 лет в Росарио, Аргентина.

Жорже был рядом и в моменты успехов сына, и в трудные для него периоды, незаметно контролируя многомиллионный бренд Месси. Он был агентом своего мальчика и выступал в роли решительного переговорщика от имени одного из величайших спортсменов всех времен. Но за громкими заголовками и деловыми сделками стоял любящий отец.

Хорхе знал, что у «Льва» есть дар, раньше всех на этой планете. Он видел величие там, где многие вокруг видели слабого ребенка с проблемами роста.

Когда Хорхе собрал чемодан и в 2000 году перевез своего 13-летнего сына через Атлантический океан, чтобы тот присоединился к «Барселоне», это навсегда изменило футбол. Звучит как голливудский сценарий, но мало кто из мальчиков в таком возрасте — не говоря уже о тех, кто знал только окрестности Росарио, — был готов уехать за тысячи километров, оставив мать, братьев и сестер.

«Мой старик всегда был рядом. Мы вместе прошли через много ужасных вещей, — сказал Месси в интервью Radio Del Plata в 2007 году. — Иногда я запирался в своей комнате и плакал в одиночестве, или он делал то же самое, а я его не видел. Мы притворялись, что с нами все в порядке, но это было не так. Мой старик спрашивал меня: «Что ты хочешь делать?»



Лионель Месси с семьей, в том числе с Хорхе, в центре, в своем доме в Росарио, 2003 год Марсело Боэри/El Grafico/Getty Images

Жизнь футболиста была чужда Месси.

Его отец был ярым болельщиком «Ньюэллс Олд Бойз» и работал на местном металлургическом заводе начальником цеха. Игроки таких клубов, как «Ньюэллс», «Бока Хуниорс», «Ривер Плейт» и сборной Аргентины, были для него богами. Хорхе познакомил юного Лионеля с аргентинским футбольным фольклором и привил ему любовь к этому виду спорта. В конце концов, именно это часто делают родители.

«Мой старик вставал в четыре утра и возвращался домой в девять вечера на ужин, практически каждый день, — рассказывал Месси [в интервью TyC Sports в 2019 году](#). — Мы редко виделись, но когда встречались, он наслаждался моим обществом. Он никогда меня не ругал. Мне так нравилось проводить с ним время, я ждал его, чтобы обнять и побыть с ним. Честно говоря, он все время работал».

In Ariel Senosiain's 2023 book *Messi, El Genio Completo* (Messi, The Complete Genius), Jorge, in a rare on-the-record interview, spoke about his celebrity son and the initial bond that defined their relationship. He debunked any notion that Messi did not enjoy football as a child — gossip that had gained traction in Argentina. "It's not true," Jorge said. "He always had a passion for the sport."

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In that interview, Jorge embraced the comparisons to fellow Argentina footballing icon Diego Maradona that have long followed his son. That discourse has centered on Maradona's shadow, and the cult of personality that the late Argentina captain still holds around the world. But Jorge chose to remember it much differently, like a proud father.

"We would go to Newell's matches together," he told Senosiain. "It became normal for us to do so after he began to play at the club as a seven-year-old. When he was 10, he watched a Newell's game pitchside. It was against Union (de Santa Fe) and he started juggling and playing with the ball at half-time. The fans began to chant,

“I would always watch (his) games by myself, and I still do to this day,” Jorge continued. “I try to sit far away from everyone.

“When he was a youth player at Barcelona, there were times when he would disconnect from what was happening during a game. I would try to get him to look over at me. I’d give him a sign, I’d try to give him a boost and I’d tell him to move. He would throw an arm gesture at me and would respond that I should leave him alone. But he would reconnect, and he’d do something marvellous with the ball.”

Jorge was speaking publicly, and graciously, after Messi had led Argentina to the 2021 Copa America title. That win ended a 28-year drought where Argentina failed to lift a trophy. Messi, however, was collecting Ballons d’Or, claiming La Liga titles and winning two Champions Leagues with Barcelona.

It was a rare interview, and one that came after years of relentless scrutiny in Argentina for his son’s failure to secure a title with the national team.

When Argentina were defeated 1-0 in the 2014 World Cup final by Germany after extra time, Messi’s solitary stare inside the Maracana stadium in Rio de Janeiro became a lasting image of that clash of titans. After they lost the following year’s Copa America final to Chile on penalties, his despair was evident, too. His vacant look captured a moment he could not understand. ‘Why him? Why now?’

A further year later, in the final of the Copa America Centenario, Argentina were beaten by Chile in another shootout. Messi sent his penalty over the crossbar. He

And while the world wondered why, he retreated to the intimate circle of trust that only one's family can provide.

One can imagine how, at that time, he must have leaned on his father through conversations [over mate](#) that would convince him to change his mind. Because in moments when Messi has seemed alone inside his own bubble, Dad was always there. A phone call away.

If that 2016 Copa America final was Messi's most distressing moment as a professional, today, he is experiencing much greater pain. The solace, perhaps, after such a loss, is that Jorge witnessed his son's most recent run towards eternal greatness.



Jorge Messi with his son's Golden Ball award as best player of the tournament at the 2022 World Cup Jean Catuffe/Getty Images

There was the tumultuous 2022 World Cup campaign that ended with victory over France in the final. An eighth Ballon d'Or followed in 2023. And then came the 2024 Copa America final defeat of Colombia.

And of course, Argentina's labored run to the 2026 World Cup final last month, with Messi at its forefront, holds greater weight [in light of what we now know he was](#)

Having previously been accused of being crippled by the pressure of representing Argentina, Lionel and Jorge, together, celebrated all the symbolic triumphs.

Messi continued to play for his country, even as Jorge dealt with a health issue during this World Cup. He was overcome with emotion after scoring his first of three goals against Algeria in their opening group game on June 16. “It was something completely unrelated to football,” he told reporters after the match. “I went through some difficult days.”

Words will do little to ease the hurt that Messi and his family are now feeling. The death of a loved one changes you.

But that is unlikely to be what Jorge would want for his son, who is now a father of three boys. In [a video message](#) he recorded for him in 2007, Jorge encouraged Messi to remember the life lessons that adversity can deliver.

“We always come out stronger,” he said.

“It helps you become who you are, because I believe that above being a good football player, you’re an excellent person. I’m not saying that because I’m your father, but because most people who know you know that’s true. And so I hope this continues for the rest of your life. That you keep being who you are, and that people love you for that.”

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